Directorate of Family Health, State of Nordmark (fictional)

Guidance Note 14: Caring for the Newborn at Home After Birth

Circular to district health teams. Supersedes Guidance Note 9.

Background

The first six weeks of life carry the greatest risk for newborns. Community health workers should see every mother and baby at least four times: first on the day of birth, again two to three days later, once more between the end of the first week and the end of the second, and finally around six weeks.

What to look for

At each visit the health worker counts the baby's breathing for one full minute. A count of sixty or fewer is within the expected range; any count above sixty means the baby is breathing too fast and must be sent to the health centre.

The baby's temperature should lie between 35.5 °C and 37.5 °C, both values included. A reading outside that range, whether higher or lower, is a reason to refer.

Ask the mother whether the baby is feeding well and whether the baby has ever had fits. Watch the baby: a baby who does not move unless stimulated, or whose lower chest pulls in sharply with each breath, needs referral. A baby who is feeding poorly or has had a fit also needs referral.

Yellow colour of the skin or eyes deserves special attention. If it appears before the baby is one full day (24 hours) old, refer. After that age, refer only when the palms of the hands and the soles of the feet are also yellow; yellow palms and soles are a reason to refer at any age.

When nothing is found

If none of these signs is present, the health worker continues routine postnatal care and counselling and schedules the next visit.

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